

LUNA 3

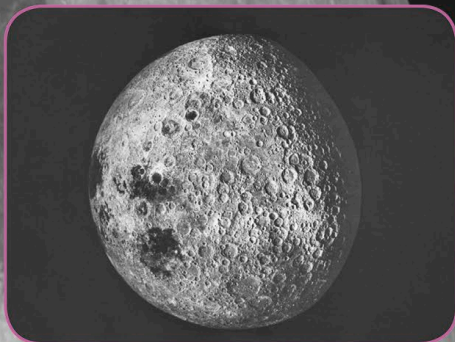
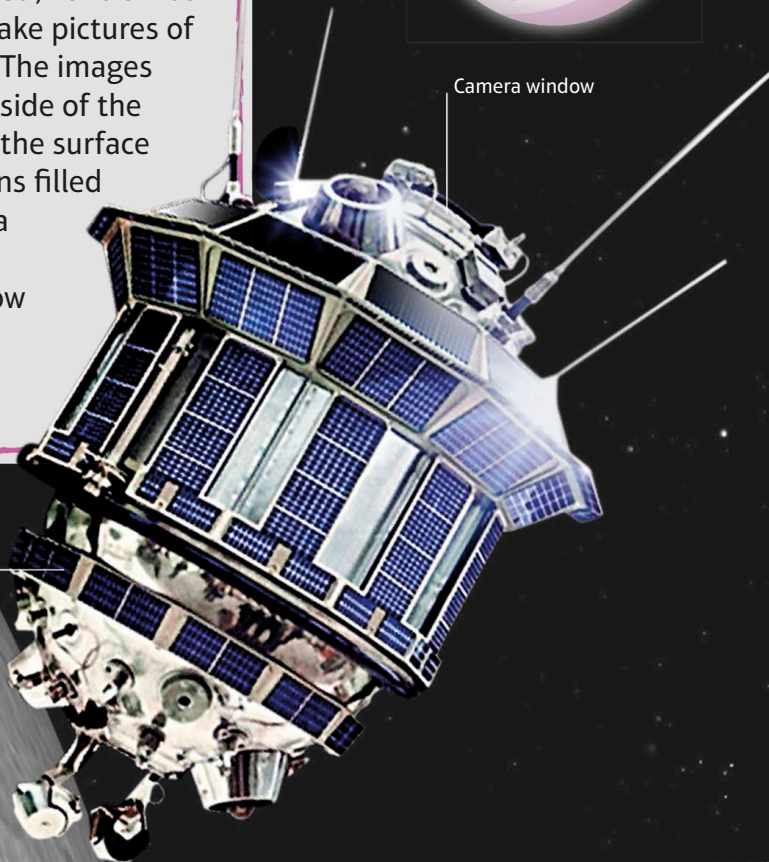
Space probe

Launched by Russia in 1959, Luna 3 was the first space probe to take pictures of the far side of the Moon. The images revealed that, unlike the side of the Moon visible from Earth, the surface had few dark maria (basins filled with solidified lava) and a huge number of craters. Scientists still do not know why the two sides of the Moon are so different.

Completing its mission, Luna 3 **looped back to Earth** and burned up in its atmosphere.

Camera window

Solar cells provided electrical power



Far side of the Moon

DATA FILE



SIZE: 1.3 m (4.2 ft) long



DATE OF LAUNCH: 4 October 1959



MISSION DURATION: 18 days (last contact)



SPACE AGENCY: Russian space program